

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Turn-Taking Instead of Forced Sharing

Scripts and research · Ages 2–4

Toddlers aren't selfish. They're just learning that other people have wants too. Turn-taking gives them a clear, fair rule, and real generosity grows from feeling safe.

What the research found

- Preschoolers who had a free choice about sharing were more generous in a later round than those who were made to share (Chernyak & Kushnir, 2013).
- Children are more likely to share when they experience it as their own choice.

Scripts that work

- For the child who wants it: “Riya is using it now. You can have it when she's done.”
- For the child playing: “Arjun is waiting. Tell him when you're finished.”
- For waiting: “Waiting is hard. Want to build a tower while you wait?”
- For grabbing: “I won't let you grab. Let's ask: 'Can I have a turn?'”
- When they give it: “You gave him a turn. Look how happy he is!”

House rules that help

- Special toys can be put away before friends visit.
- Shared toys (like a swing) can use a sand timer.
- A child can keep a toy until they are done, within reason.

What NOT to do

- Don't take a toy out of a child's hands to give it to another.
- Don't label: “Don't be selfish.”
- Don't force an apology for not sharing.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Chernyak, N., & Kushnir, T. (2013). Giving preschoolers choice increases sharing behavior. Psychological Science, 24(10), 1971–1979.

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